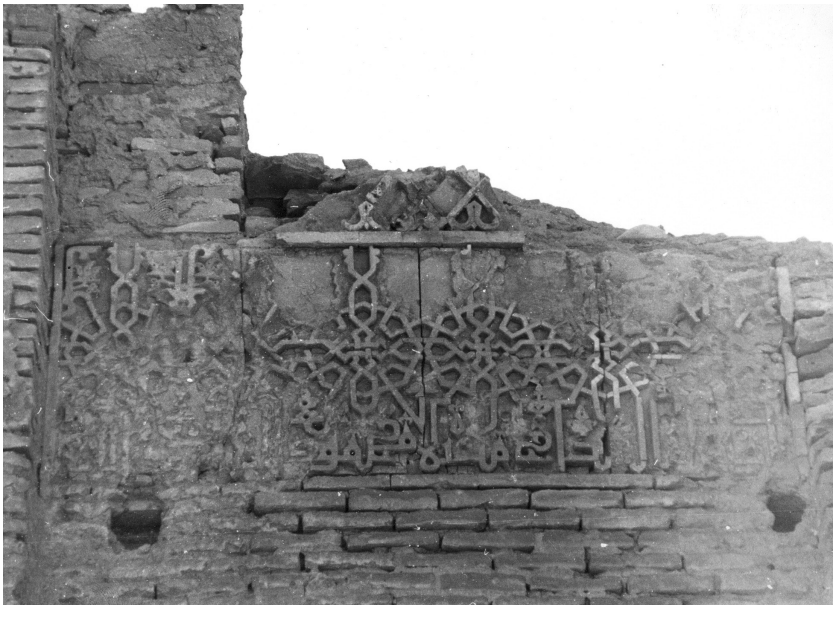


***Figure 4.8*** *Shah-i Mashhad* madrasa*, south façade, detail of inscription.*
*© Photograph Bernt Glatzer c. 1970.*

In fact, it is not unreasonable to propose that the Shansabani elites themselves were unable to read inscriptions in their entirety, much less determine the *minutiae* of their content or the overall compositions of the epigraphic programs. Two broader historical realities bolster the idea that literary documentation and literacy in general – as understood in the modern sense – were not common throughout Afghanistan during our period of focus. First, the historical trajectory of the Shansabani elites and their emergence from – and likely some maintenance of – pre-imperial transhumance and/or nomadism made for a selective knowledge of the "Great Traditions" of Islamic juridical and theological doctrines, and perhaps even Islamic religious practices.[51] Among the Shansabanis' forebears – spanning an array of lifestyles across the nomad–urban continuum (cf. Introduction and Chapter 2) – literacy was not always a requisite, nor was it necessarily widespread: the past and present of many self-identifying groups, for example, were frequently recorded and preserved in collective memory and transmitted orally across generations, captured in written form only a considerable time afterward, if at all.[52]

We have seen that the vast differences between urban center and hinterland were instrumental in the version of "Islam" that was propagated: while some Karrami legal and theological scholars were known to have been the erudite interlocutors of other *madhhab*s in Khurasan's great emporia,[53] their comrades' proselytism of a thoroughly simplified version of Islam among non-urban inhabitants – embodied in the Karrami tenet that mere